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NEWSPAPER

5th September, 2017

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

36th WEEK



PM VISIT TO MYANMAR

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II... INDIA AND ITS NEIGHBORHOOD- RELATIONS.



Learning Space

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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS ... DISCUSSION

5th SEPTEMBER, 2017

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Making up for lost time

In the past half century, India and Myanmar have lost the habit of thinking of themselves as neighbours



GAUTAM NUKHOPADHYAYA

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's remarks on an official visit to Myanmar from September 5, the follow-up to his earlier ASEAN visit, and in November 2014 and former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's visit in May 2002, through meetings, taking into account Mr. Modi's 'Neighbourhood First', 'Act East' and 'Look East' policies, international and domestic developments since then have clarified the political context of the visit. In the past half century, India and Myanmar have lost the habit of thinking of themselves as neighbours. These include the impact of decline in Myanmar in November 2015 and the US State Dept that brought Army Gen Min Aye's National League for Democracy (NLD) to power in Myanmar and Donald Trump in the US; the finalisation of China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) and its consequences in the South China Sea; the Indian-Chinese border stand-off; and Myanmar's turmoil over the peace process, the Rohingya, and internal terrorism.

The Rohingya crisis

The visit is taking place amidst some of the worst violence involving Rohingya militants and the Myanmar security forces over its rights in full-fledged internal and crisis triggered by large-scale, coordinated attacks by Rohingya militants under a recently formed Arakan Army Salwa Juy Jaka, now designated as terrorist, against government and security forces in northern Rakhine state on August 25-26.

Thousands of civilians were killed, against a backdrop of decades of violence against the Rohingyas, widespread arson and burning of villages allegedly by both sides; displacement of thousands within Rakhine state and across the Nat state in Thailand; and severe deprivation in food and humanitarian supplies. The Modi government has unequivocally



condemned the 'heinous' attacks at a time when the security forces and the armed forces have been facing international criticism on the handling of the issue. This is likely to be similar to Mr. Modi's focus on Myanmar.

The visit is also taking place against the backdrop of uncertainties in the future Indian-China relationship caused by the new defence and India's stand-off and the BRI's economic sanction to be less than between the two Asian giants. Myanmar is keen to leverage the growth potential of good relations with India's ever-faster growing economy. But this also means economic dependence on China, characterised by a largely asymmetrical relationship focused on natural resources and access to the Bay of Bengal where it already has oil and gas terminal, concession to build a Special Economic Zone and seeks special customs privileges in a natural deep-sea harbour at Kyaukse that could form part of its own BRI. The decline of China's share likely to be kept large over the state. Myanmar would welcome closer economic ties with India's reform and reform in connecting ties with China. China's influence in a Great Game East between India and China are, however, greatly weakened.

Focus on basics Beyond these urgent issues, and the issue of Indian insurgent groups in Myanmar, which remain a matter of concern, the agenda of Mr. Modi's much-anticipated visit will most likely be taken up by the fundamentals of the bilateral relationship: the subcontinent's development, security, trade, security, and neutral of culture, and people to people ties. Defence relations have been going steadily, especially between the two armies and navy. Security related talks have been taking place at the Regional Security Dialogue (RSD) level.

A number of bilateral agreements in the areas of capacity building, health, culture, and development, and one on maritime security are on the anvil, building on the success of 2014 in developing partnership with Myanmar to face. These cover large, directly funded and assisted investment in infrastructure projects like the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, the Kaladan Multi-modal Transport and Transit Project, high-value capacity and human development projects like the Myanmar Institute of Technology, and the success of India's first 'hot' springs in Myanmar; more modest ones in industry, IT, health, entrepreneurship, and language training, and border area development projects in Chin and Kachin areas of Myanmar, and others that could be added. India's foreign aid to Myanmar is around \$100 million, much of it still remains to be utilised.

Though this may not be all, given the progress in Myanmar, few countries are underlining such large-scale investment and development projects and of government funds to India. When they are all completed and fully operational by around 2020, they will amount to a substantial trade and security expanded relationship.

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Similarly, the commitment to trade of commercial trade, and to economic, both stand on various issues, primary agricultural and forest products from Myanmar in various of trade, and of and as in case of investment, maintaining a strong need to expand, diversify and upgrade commercial ties in ways that also ensure to share more development needs and meet India's \$3 billion trade target set in 2012.

The bilateral relations, which made last year the best of our post-independence relationship first survival with the intervention of the 1960s by the military government of Ne Win and the Western economic sanctions since the crackdown on democratic aspirations starting from the 1980s. Critical incidents are Indian imports of rice and other food grains, which part in our food security and Myanmar's economy. Smuggling of around a million tonnes and \$1 billion in value, over 50% of which is exported to India, is a major concern. Myanmar's economy, greater even in the value of its exports of rice to China that we prime to purchase medicines, rough inspections and crackdowns on historical trade in Myanmar-China border, but also the impact of Myanmar's economy in India as an alternative to China, have benefited on good public-private investment in India and should be opened.

Unfortunately, the recent decision to impose quantitative restrictions on the trade in goods, especially the opposite, notwithstanding recent relations on trade, which is a good thing, there is a concern over the impact of a one-sided, closed trade in goods that has resulted in a trade deficit and a trade deficit in trade. The objective should be to increase and protect domestic production in India and in Myanmar, and to move towards a government channelised trade to stabilise prices and in part on account of economic in such a manner in Myanmar.

Older ties Besides trade, our strong cultural, people to people and diaspora relationship, Mr. Modi will also visit

Bagan, where the Archaeological Survey of India is in the process of a \$100m to the renovated Ananda Temple and where the Cabinet has approved Indian assistance for the restoration of pagodas damaged by the powerful 2008 earthquake and Bagan, where he will address the Indian origin and Indian community and visit places religious, cultural and historical importance.

In his official meetings with President Htin Kyaw and State Counsellor Aun Mye Thaw, Mr. Modi is likely to forge a bold strategic vision for bilateral relations, taking advantage of the consensus cutting across political parties and civil and military pillars of Myanmar's polity towards stronger ties with India, and protect India's economic and strategic interests in the region between the Bay of Bengal in the South China Sea.

Key elements of this vision could be greater strategic to strategic political focus, ethnic states, and the peace process as part of our democratic political process, converting our investments in the Trilateral Highway and the Kaladan to further trade and investment corridors and use Indian investment in the Greater Kachin Sub region as an example of foreign policy with a focus on agriculture, agro-forestry and light industry, a broader development partnership reaching to the grassroots with the help of civil society, specific projects in our 'One East policy' through the North-east India Gateway as a platform, and a new political approach to the IG line Indian in support groups based on multi-party cooperation. These could be a good thing and cooperation in a joint document, source of work.

The objective should be to increase the balance in Myanmar's relations between East and South Asia that has been lost with the inward turn Myanmar's external relations over 50 years of Indian military rule during which the two countries have forgotten the habit of thinking of themselves as neighbours.

GAUTAM NUKHOPADHYAYA is a senior editor at The Hindu.

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PM Modi's visit to Myanmar is an opportunity to improve business and strategic ties and bolster the Look East policy



The volatile situation in the Rohingya state is also likely to be deepened. In the aftermath of the recent incidence of terrorism in the state by the Rohingya radical group, ARSA, a fresh wave of fear psychosis made their way to fledgled adsh and other countries in the region – adding to the Rohingya refugee population in these countries. Some 40,000 Rohingyas have had to find their way to India. This compels us to build a soft fence. A fence



With Myanmar's government emphasizing higher education and vocational training, more Indian-assisted institutions can come up in the country. Scholarships for university students are also available for students from Myanmar.

Lacking a few outfits, large Indian business groups are conspicuous by their absence: Chinese, Singaporean, Korean.

Three regional hubs in food and investment. Bilateral trade between the two countries has, for long, remained at around \$2 billion. India ranks fifth among Myanmar's import sources and 10th among foreign investors. Barring a few outliers, large Indian business groups are conspicuous by their absence. Chinese, Singaporean, Korean, Japanese, Thai and Vietnamese businesses have actively sought business opportunities in Myanmar. Admittedly, the regulatory and economic environment has to evolve in Myanmar to enhance the common level of



PREVAILING CIRCUMSTANCES

ISSUE NO:1

ROHINGYA CRISIS



- 1 Rohingya militants under Arakan Rohingya Salvation Army (ARSA) attacked Government and security outposts in northern Rakhine state on August 25-26.
- 2 Subsequently, attacks and clearance operations started, which resulted in around 1,000 deaths, mostly Rohingyas.
- 3 Widespread arson and burning of villages allegedly by both the sides took place.
- 4 This led to displacement of thousands within Rakhine state and across the Naf river to Bangladesh.

The Indian Government has unequivocally condemned the terrorist attacks

PREVAILING CIRCUMSTANCES

ISSUE NO: 2

INDIA-CHINA AND CHINA'S INVESTMENTS IN MYANMAR

Making up for lost time

In the past half century, India and Myanmar have lost the habit of thinking of themselves as neighbours.



CHITRAKUT

For a country like India, which has a long and glorious history, it is a shame that it has lost the habit of thinking of itself as a neighbour. In the past half century, India and Myanmar have lost the habit of thinking of themselves as neighbours. This is a shame for a country like India, which has a long and glorious history.

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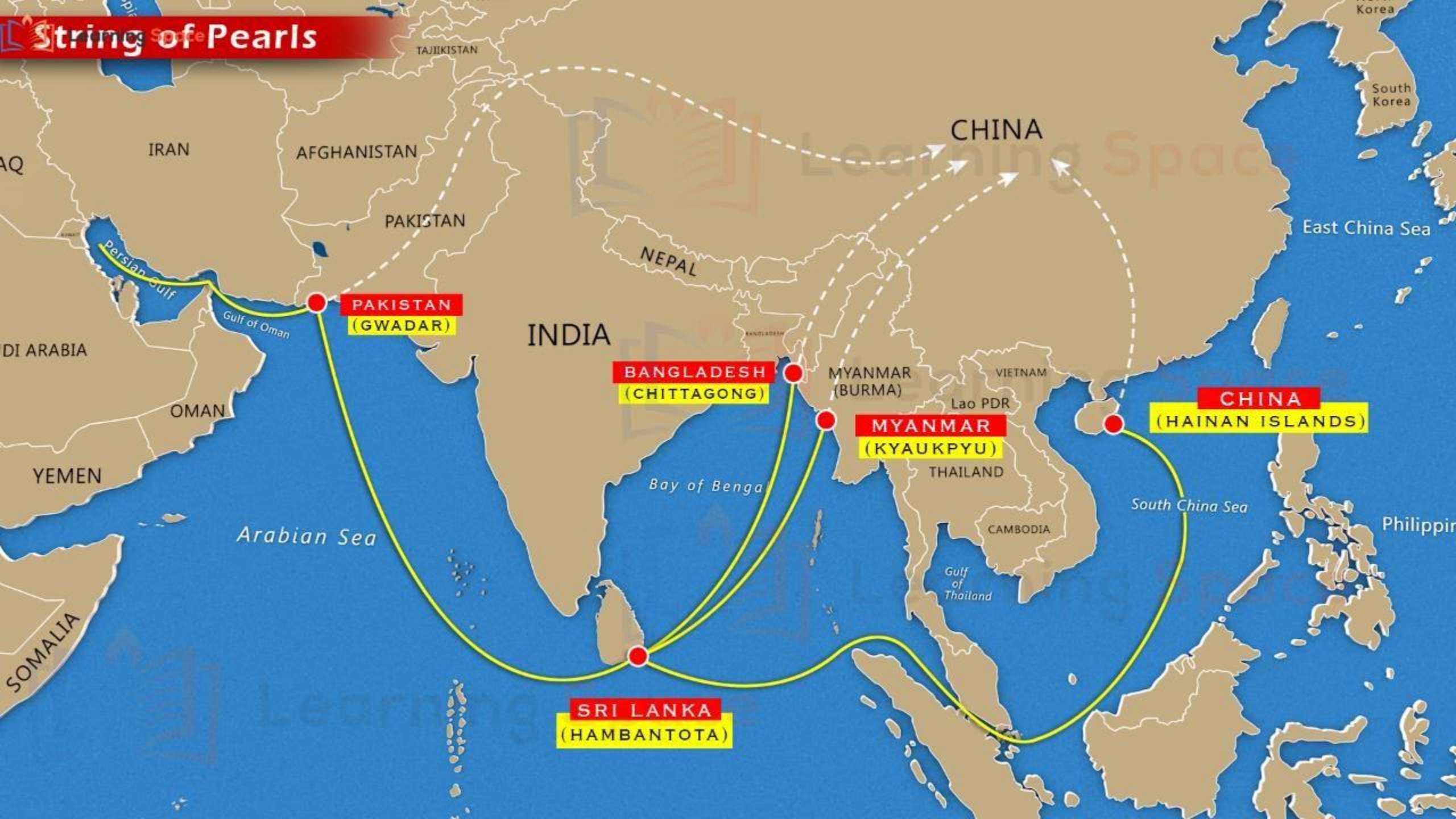
Date: 5th September, 2017

1 The India's relations with China in the near future is uncertain because of Doklam.

2 China's relationship with Myanmar are extractive in nature. It already has an oil and gas terminal near Bay of Bengal coast.

3 China is going to build Special Economic Zone. Now it is asking for controlling stake in a natural deep sea harbour at Kyaukpyu that could form part of its ambitious BRI .

A shadow of China looms large over the visit



String of Pearls

PAKISTAN
(GWADAR)

BANGLADESH
(CHITTAGONG)

MYANMAR
(KYAUKPYU)

CHINA
(HAINAN ISLANDS)

SRI LANKA
(HAMBANTOTA)



PREVAILING CIRCUMSTANCES

ISSUE NO: 3

INDIAN INSURGENT GROUPS



The Indian insurgent groups with bases in Myanmar remains a matter of concern



INDIA & MYANMAR ... SLOW PACE OF DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS

So far India built \$2 billion development partnership with Myanmar.

- They cover the large directly funded and executed connectivity/ infrastructure projects like the Trilateral Highway, the Kaladan Multi-modal Transport and Transit Project.
- High value capacity and human development projects like the Myanmar Institute of Information Technology in Mandalay.
- Small border area development projects in Chin and Naga areas of Myanmar
- Soft lines of credit for other infrastructure projects amounting to nearly \$750 million.

However, there is slow pace of progress and once they are completed say by about 2020, it will have its own impact on the people of the country





NEPAL

BHUTAN

CHINA

INDIA

BANGLADESH

Manipur

Moreh

Myanmar
(Burma)

Mandalay

Bay of Bengal

Mae Sot

THAILAND

Yangon



WHAT ABOUT TRADE AND INVESTMENTS



1 Import of beans and pulses play a vital part in our food security and Myanmar's economy.

2 They are at around a million tonnes and \$1 billion in value, over 90% of which is exported to India.

3 It is vital to Myanmar's farmers and foreign exchange earnings.

4 Rice exports to China are prone to periodic restrictions, tough inspections and crackdowns on informal trade at Myanmar-China border.

Now, we can think of opening up a limited market for Myanmar rice in India and some quantitative restrictions were imposed on pulses recently and this issue is to be looked at.



CULTURAL ... PEOPLE TO PEOPLE TIES



Making up for lost time

In the past half century, India and Myanmar have lost the habit of thinking of themselves as neighbours



CHITRA KUMAR

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent visit to Myanmar has reignited the long-standing relationship between the two nations. The visit is a significant step towards strengthening the ties between the two countries, which have been strained for decades.



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1

India and Myanmar have got strong cultural, people-to-people and diaspora relationship.

2

This is evident, with the Prime Minister visiting Bagan, where the Archaeological Survey of India is in the final stages of a face-lift to the "Ananda Temple".

3

The restoration of pagodas damaged by powerful 2016 earthquake are going to be done with Indian assistance.

4

The Prime Minister is also visiting places of religious, cultural and historical importance.

**WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE**

- 1** Converting our investments in the trilateral highway and the kaladan projects to fuller trade and investment corridors.
- 2** Use of Indian investments in the Greater Mekong Sub-region as an arm of our foreign policy with a focus on agriculture, agro-industries and light industries.
- 3** A broader development partnership to the grassroots with the help of civil society.
- 4** New political approach to the Indian Insurgent Groups issue beyond the intelligence-based approaches.
- 5** Giving more impetus to policy through North-East and Bodhgaya as pilgrimage centres.



The objective is to restore the balance in Myanmar's relations between East and South Asia that has been lost with the Eastward tilt in Myanmar's external relations over 50 years insular military rule.

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For Suggestions:

suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

OUR TEAM

G. V. Rao

D. Sunil Kumar
V. Dayakar James
Y. Sri Poojita

G. Ravi Babu
D. Joji
K. Victor Babu

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